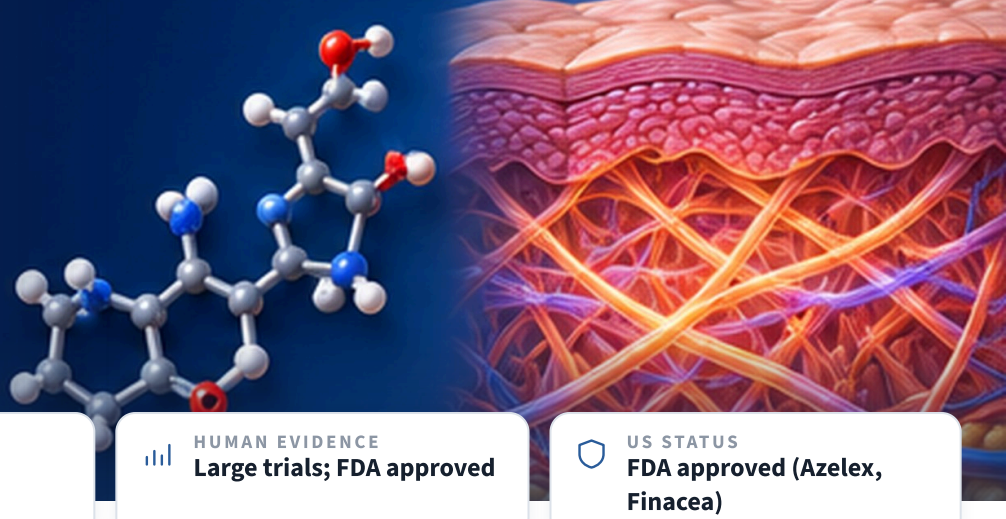
SKIN
02

Azelaic acid

Naturally occurring saturated dicarboxylic acid, found in whole grains and made in small amounts by the body



CLASS
Dicarboxylic acid (topical)

STUDIED FOR
Acne, rosacea

HUMAN EVIDENCE
Large trials; FDA approved

US STATUS
FDA approved (Azelex, Finacea)

STUDIED FOR

Rosacea	Acne
HUMAN	HUMAN

Combinations are untested. No published trial of a cream combining azelaic acid and niacinamide turned up in a PubMed search (Oct 2026).

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Azelaic acid → Skin bacteria → Thinner outer skin → Fewer comedones

- **Exact mechanism** is not known, per the Azelex label
- **In lab tests,** active against two skin bacteria; clinical meaning unknown
- **Skin biopsies** showed a thinner outer layer and less filaggrin
- **In rosacea,** the way it works is unknown, per the Finacea label

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

FDA APPROVED
LEVEL 5 OF 5

- Azelex approved 1995; Finacea gel 2002
- 2 rosacea RCTs, 664 people, 12 weeks
- Bumps fell 50.0–57.9% vs 38.2–39.9% (vehicle)

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Use in dark skin
- Use in pregnancy
- Effect on redness alone

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE
About 12 hours after skin use; 45 minutes by mouth

ROUTES STUDIED
On the skin (cream, gel, foam)

PHARMACOKINETICS
About 4% absorbed; mainly excreted unchanged in urine

SOLD AS
Prescription cream, gel and foam (Azelex, Finacea, generics)

MONITORED IN TRIALS
Skin reactions; skin lightening in dark skin

SPORT (WADA)
Not on the 2026 list

REGULATORY

FDA	Approved: acne (1995), rosacea (2002, 2015)
FDA	Compounded combinations are not FDA approved
DEA	Not a controlled substance
WADA	Not on the 2026 list

REFERENCES

1. FDA, Azelex prescribing information (DailyMed), Mar 2024
2. FDA, Finacea gel 15% prescribing information (DailyMed), Apr 2011
3. WADA, 2026 Prohibited List

Adonis Men's Health · checked Nov 2026. Research and regulator records only. Not medical advice.

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